the US president, urging him to allow smooth supply chains, following which NSA Doval spoke with his counterpart in the US, Jake Sullivan, to discuss the finer points of the arrangement. The next day, Sullivan, in a statement, confirmed, '[The] United States has identified sources of specific raw material urgently required for Indian manufacture of Covishield vaccine that will immediately be made available for India.'[48] Due to relentless efforts from the very top of the government, supply chains remained open and Indian manufacturers were able to produce the large quantities required. However, when India suspended the Vaccine Maitri programme, from a security and market standpoint, we made way for the Chinese vaccine makers to access markets which were mostly dominated by Indian companies. A major Indian vaccine manufacturer would later vent, 'The people who created such a hue and cry about stopping the vaccine exports are such buffoons. They don't understand how much Modiji's vaccine export programme strengthened India's position in terms of bilateral and multilateral relations. Now that the Chinese and Koreans have taken over critical markets, due to our vaccine unavailability, how are we going to reclaim our positions of strength there?'

Case in point is SII's experience. Describing his frustrations, Mr Poonawalla said, 'Just when the pandemic began in March 2020, I was certain that SII would play a role in ensuring India's security. I first raised over 10,000 crores from the global community way back in March 2020, followed by another round of 6,000 crores. Most of this money came from countries which had placed advance orders with SII and some came from the COVAX program—under which SII was bound to supply a certain amount of doses to middle- and low-income countries within a certain time frame. In fact, with the export ban, SII was in such a tough spot that I had to offer to return this money we had raised.' The damage that the opposition network had done to India's credibility was immense. In fact, months later, when the prime minister spoke at the Global COVID-19 Summit, he had to commit to resuming vaccine exports in order to continue being a beneficiary of the global vaccine supply chain, assuring, 'We are leveraging India's manufacturing strength to produce vaccines for the Indo-Pacific region with the help of Quad partners. And as our production increases, we will be able to resume vaccine supplies to others too. For this, the supply chains of raw materials must be kept open.'[49]